

THE LONG ODDS

Written by

A. Roy

SECOND DRAFT (Blue) - August 28, 2026

FADE IN:

INT. MERIDIAN AUTO BODY - GARAGE BAY - NIGHT

Rain hammers a corrugated roof. Sparks fall from a welding torch.

DESMOND HALE, 40s, grease to the elbows, kills the torch and lifts his mask. Behind him, a wall calendar from ZENITH MOTORS hangs crooked, the logo faded.

A radio in the corner plays "Sweet Child O' Mine" through static.

DESMOND

You're three weeks late, Marty.

MARTY OKONKWO, 30s, jittery, stands in the doorway holding a soaked paper bag.

MARTY

I got most of it.

DESMOND

Most of it isn't it.

Marty sets the bag down. A can of Coca-Cola rolls out and comes to rest against Desmond's boot.

MARTY

There's a guy. Buys salvage titles, doesn't ask questions. Pays in cash.

DESMOND

There's always a guy.

MARTY

This one's real. Calls himself Cortland. Runs it out of the old Kilbray building on 1400 Ashland.

Desmond wipes his hands. Says nothing.

CUT TO:

INT. DESMOND'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

A cramped room. A television bolted high in the corner plays a scene from THE GODFATHER, sound off.

Desmond drops into a chair. On the desk: a copy of the CHICAGO TRIBUNE, folded to the business section.

He picks up a landline and dials.

DESMOND
(into phone)
Yeah. It's Hale. Put me through to
the claims desk.
(beat)
No, the direct line. 312-555-0147.

He waits. On the wall behind him hangs a print of Edward
Hopper's NIGHTHAWKS, the frame cracked.

DESMOND (CONT'D)
Tell Vandermeer at STATE FARM I
want the file on the Kessler wreck.

CUT TO:

EXT. ASHLAND AVENUE - NIGHT

A black sedan idles at the curb. Illinois plate: KJ-4471.

CORTLAND VOSS, 50s, expensive coat, steps out. He checks a
phone, then the building.

CORTLAND
(into phone)
Send it to voss@zenithmotors.com.
Tonight.

He pockets the phone and goes inside.

CUT TO:

INT. KILBRAY BUILDING - FREIGHT ELEVATOR - CONTINUOUS

Cortland rides up. Fluorescent light stutters.

He unfolds a printout. The header reads NORTHWESTERN
MEMORIAL HOSPITAL. Below it, a name: DR. ALAN REINHOLT,
CARDIOLOGY.

CORTLAND
(to himself)
Four signatures. That's all this
is.

CUT TO:

INT. KILBRAY BUILDING - FOURTH FLOOR - NIGHT

An open floor. Filing boxes. Two men wait: BRICK, huge, and a YOUNGER MAN at a laptop.

YOUNGER MAN
Site's up. Registered it this
morning. midwestsalvageauth.com.
Looks official enough.

CORTLAND
It doesn't need to look official.
It needs to look boring.

Brick laughs. Cortland doesn't.

CORTLAND (CONT'D)
The Reinholt signature. How close?

YOUNGER MAN
Close.

CORTLAND
Close is what put Kessler in the
ground.

The Younger Man stops typing.

CUT TO:

INT. STATE FARM REGIONAL CLAIMS - DAY

NEW SCENE. Rows of cubicles. VANDERMEER, 50s, tie loosened, slides a folder across his desk to Cortland.

VANDERMEER
Eleven files. All of them mine. All
of them approved.

CORTLAND
And nobody upstairs asked.

VANDERMEER
Nobody upstairs reads. That's the
product.

Vandermeer signs. Cortland pockets the folder. Behind them, a STATE FARM banner runs the length of the wall.

CUT TO:

INT. MERIDIAN AUTO BODY - GARAGE BAY - LATER

Desmond stands over an engine block, not working. Marty watches him.

MARTY

You're gonna do something stupid.

DESMOND

I'm gonna do something slow.

He pulls a cardboard box from under the bench. Inside:
manila folders, decades of them.

DESMOND (CONT'D)

Eleven cars. Same adjuster, same
doctor, same signature. Six years.

MARTY

Why'd you keep 'em?

DESMOND

Because I knew I'd need them and I
hoped I wouldn't.

He sets one folder aside. On the tab, in marker: KESSLER.

FADE OUT.

END OF EXCERPT